TRAIL TOOL

Budget Builder: My Zero-Based Budget

A zero-based budget gives every dollar coming in this month a job, until there are zero dollars left without one.

Saving is a job. Paying down debt is a job. Fun is a job too. The point isn't to spend less on everything. It's to decide on purpose, before the money is gone, instead of wondering at the end of the month where it went.

Rename any category so it fits your life. Rounded or practice numbers work just as well as exact ones.

Two ways to use this handout. It matches the Budget Builder in the Pathfinder Guidebook. Print it and fill it in by hand, or type in the boxes below and save a PDF. You'll use it for Question 4 of Mile Marker #5. You never have to share your budget. If you want to attach it, that's your choice.

NAME _____ **MONTH OF** _____

STEP 1

Money coming in this month

If your income changes month to month, plan on the lowest amount you can count on. If more comes in, give the extra a job then.

Source	Amount
Paychecks this month	$
Financial aid for this month	$
Help from family	$
Other money coming in	$
Total coming in	**$**

STEP 2

Give every dollar a job

Start with your Musts, like housing, food, and getting to school and work. Then the rest. Keep going until Left to assign reaches $0.

Category	Amount
Housing: rent or share of rent	$
Utilities and phone	$
Groceries	$
Transportation: gas, car, rides	$
Car insurance or other insurance	$
School costs	$
Debt or loan payments	$
Savings or emergency fund	$
Personal and household	$
Fun and social	$
Giving or family support	$
Subscriptions	$
	$
	$
Total assigned	**$**

Left to assign (total coming in minus total assigned):

STEP 3

Why these jobs?

Why did you choose these categories, and what did giving every dollar a job show you?